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STAR CAMPAIGNER: Congress chief Sonia Gandhi has been a successful crowd-puller at rallies

due to floods and non-seasonal rains. The Congress is trying to depict the Government as arrogant and one that lacks a human touch because of its strong stance on tax collection.

The party is also harping on Modi's alleged failure to provide power for 14 hours to farmers as against Modi's claim that under the Jyotirgram power distribution scheme, 24-hour power will be available in all villages. Deepak Babaria, state Congress general secretary, says: "Modi promised people the moon in his hyped terminology. His claims are tall but empty. Our campaign aims at trapping him in his hype. Modi's arrogance will defeat him." The party knows that urban areas are overtly pro-Modi and is therefore focussing on rural areas.

In keeping with this plan, the party has been issuing advertisements in newspapers attacking Modi's claims on development. One Congress ad last week said, "Gujarat will win only when BJP loses." The ad then "bust" the chief minister's claims by countering him on a series of points and ended with, "How can Gujarat win at the hands of those who defeated Gujarat? A

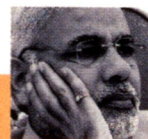
Congress victory is victory for 5.5 crore Gujaratis. Now, change is the only remedy." The enthusiasm in the Congress is partly due to the fact that it is flush with funds and has provided an Innova car to each of its 225 taluka panchayat presidents. Another reason for this enthusiasm is that almost the entire local press is ranged against Modi and is pro-Congress.

The poll meetings of Sonia Gandhi, the party's main campaigner, have been successful in terms of turnout and enthusiasm. Says Manish Doshi, the Gujarat Congress spokesperson: "With a strong and rightly pitched campaign, we have been successful in denting Modi's image that he had assiduously cultivated over the years". The Congress' biggest hurdle is Modi's portrayal of the party being soft on terror-

ism and his repeated use of delay in capital punishment for Afzal Guru and the replacement of TADA with POTA while comparing it with his own anti-terror record in Gujarat.

The Congress attempt to project the Government's poor record on law and order to neutralise Modi's claims on security may not cut much ice. Another obstacle for the Congress is

that despite the unity that Ahmed Patel, the reticent political advisor to Sonia Gandhi, has forged amongst the once-squabbling state unit, the party hasn't been able to project a chief minister and therefore its campaign lacks a face. Another challenge for the Congress is to wipe Modi's strong image from the minds of women and youth. It will be a surprise if the Congress is able to do that and a bigger surprise if it wins. ■



The biggest drawback the Congress faces is that it has not been able to provide an alternative to Modi

